On the multifunctionality of Vietnamese *là*

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Syntax 4

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1 Some background on Vietnamese non-verbal constructions

The basic sentence structure in Vietnamese has the SVO order.

(1) Tôi ăn cái bánh rồi.
1SG eat CL-cake PST
'I ate the cake already.'

Là is commonly known for its role as a copular particle. However, non-verbal constructions in Vietnamese vary in the presence of *là*.

(2) Cô ấy là giáo viên.
3SG.FEM LA teacher
'She is a teacher.'

(3) Cô ấy (*là) rất đẹp.
3SG.FEM LA very pretty
'She is very pretty.'

(4) Cô ấy (*là) ở nhà.
3SG.FEM LA LOC[1] home
'She is at home.'

Phan and Duffield (2022) point out that this function of *là* can extend to the use of identification.

(5) RC predicate

a. Cô ấy là người mua bánh.
3SG.FEM LA person buy cake
'She is the person who bought the cake.'

b. Người mua bánh là cô ấy.
person buy cake LA 3SG.FEM
'The person who bought the cake is her.'

A similar phenomenon—that only nominal predicates may occur with an overt copula—is observed in Mandarin Chinese and Korean.

[1] Phan and Duffield (2022) gloss this particle as LOC.COP (locative copula?) in their examples, although they don't give reason for why they do so.

(6) Chinese (from Huang et al. 2009:25)

a. Nominal predication

Ta shi yingxiong
he be hero
'He is a hero.'

b. Adjectival predication

Ta (*shi) hen yingyong.
he be very heroic
'He is very heroic.'

(7) Korean (from Cho & Whitman 2020:194-7)

a. Nominal predication

Chelswu=ka haksayng=i-ta.
Chelswu=NOM student=be-PLN
'Chelswu is a student.'

b. Adjectival predication

Chelswu=ka manhi kippu-ta.
Chelswu=NOM a lot happy-PLN
'Chelswu is very happy.'

Vietnamese negated nominal predicate constructions behave differently from those in Chinese and Korean.

(8) Vietnamese

Cô ấy không phải (là) kẻ ngốc.
3SG.FEM NEG-right LA CL-fool
'She is not a fool.'

(9) Chinese

Ta bu-*(shi) shazi.
She NEG-be fool
'She is not a fool.'

(10) Korean (from Cho & Whitman 2020)

Swuni=nun papo=ka ani-ta.
Swuni=TOP fool=NOM not.be-PLN
'Swuni is not a fool.'

2 *Là* as a multifunctional category: non-copular uses

Travis (2006) defines multifunctional category as when "the same lexical item can appear to have a different categorial signature as well as different argument structure depending on the details of the syntactic realization." That is, a single lexical item may exhibit different syntactic behaviors depending on the structural position it occupies within the clause.

2.1. Complementizer *là*

Phan and Duffield (2022) categorizes non-copular *là* into either a complementizer or a topic marker. They also claim that only the topic marker *là* may be followed by adjectival predicate (and locative predicate?).

(11) Complementizer *là*

Tôi	nghĩ	(*là)	(rằng)	(là)	anh ấy	có lý.
1SG	think	LA	C	LA	3SG.MASC	have-reason

'I think he is right.'

(12) Cleft-like sentences: topic marker *là* (P&D 2022) or emphatic copula *là*?

a.

Ngủ	được	là	tốt.
sleep	able	LA	good

'Being able to sleep is good.'

b.

Ai	cũng	đi	học,	mỗi	nó	là	ở	nhà.
who	OP	go	study	only	3SG	LA	LOC	home

'Everyone went to school; only he/she stayed at home.'

Can nominalization constructions occur with *rằng*?

(13)

a.

Có	một	sự thật	(?rằng)	là	tôi	không	thích	dứa.
have	one	fact	C	LA	1SG	NEG	like	pineapple

'There is a fact that I don't like pineapples.'

b.

Tôi không biết	một	điều –	rằng	mình	đã trở thành…	(a Threads post)
1SG NEG-know	one	thing	C	1SG	ANT-become	

'I didn't know one thing: (that) I had become…'

Hypothesis: what *là* can precede (in certain cases where *rằng* cannot) is actually a nominalized clause.

(14)

a.

(Điều)	quan trọng	là	bạn	phải	bình tĩnh.
thing	important	LA	2SG	must	calm

'The important thing is that you stay calm.'

b. *(Điều) quan trọng rằng bạn phải bình tĩnh.
(intended meaning as (13a))

(15) Q:

Ai	ăn	cái bánh này	rồi?
Who.Q	eat	CL-cake-this	already

'Who ate this cake?'

a. A:

Tôi	nghĩ	rằng	là	anh ấy	ăn	(cái bánh)	rồi.
1SG	think	C	LA	3SG.MASC	eat	(CL-cake)	already

'I think he ate it.'

b. A':

Tôi	nghĩ	là	anh ấy.
1SG	think	LA	3SG.MASC

'I think it's him.'

c. A': *Tôi nghĩ rằng anh ấy.
1SG think C 3SG.MASC
Intended: 'I think it's him.'

Duffield (2025) claims that "*là* has a semantic status intermediate between *rằng* and *liệu*: whereas *rằng* is typically associated with propositional assertions, and *liệu* with alternative questions, *là* is apparently neutral between the two types of complement"

(16) (from Duffield 2025, item (21)a-b)

a. Người mẹ không biết ***rằng**/liệu bọn trẻ đang ngủ hay thức.
mother NEG know COMP/INT children PROG sleep or awake
'The mother doesn't know whether the kids are sleeping or awake.'
(= the mother is unsure about whether her kids are asleep.)

b. Người mẹ không biết [rằng/***liệu** [bọn trẻ có đang ngủ.]]
mother NEG know COMP/INT children ASR PROG sleep
'The mother doesn't know that the kids are in fact sleeping.'
(= the kids are in fact asleep: the mother doesn't know that fact)

(17) (from Duffield 2025, item (22)a-b)

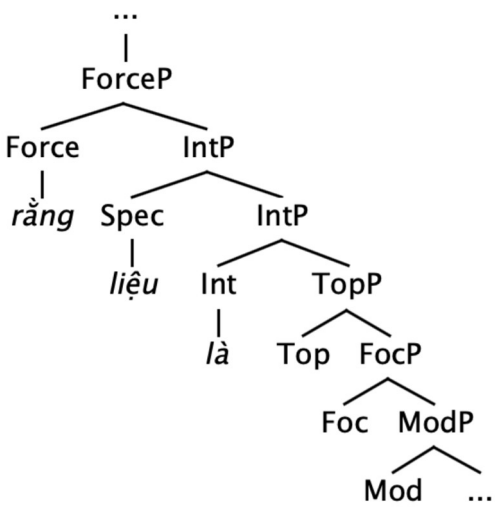
a. Người mẹ không biết **là** bọn trẻ đang ngủ hay thức.
mother NEG know ?? children PROG sleep or awake
'The mother doesn't know whether the kids are sleeping or awake.'
(= the mother is unsure about whether her kids are asleep.)

b. Người mẹ không biết **là** bọn trẻ có đang ngủ.]
mother NEG know ?? children ASR PROG sleep
'The mother doesn't know that the kids are sleeping.'
(i.e., the kids are in fact asleep: the mother doesn't know that fact)

There are also cases where *rằng, liệu,* and *là* may co-occur. (prosody?)

(18) Người mẹ hỏi rằng liệu (là) bọn trẻ đang ngủ hay thức.
CL-mother ask C INT LA PL-child PROG-sleep-or-awake
'The mother asked whether the kids are sleeping or awake.'

(19) (Duffield 2025, item (29))



2.2. Topic marker *là*

In topicalization constructions, *là* can optionally surface after the topic marker *thì*, or occur on its own, following the topicalized element.

(20)

a. Cái bánh thì (là) anh ấy mua.
CL-cake TM LA 3SG.MASC buy
'As for the cake, he bought it.'

b. Cái bánh là anh ấy mua.
CL-cake LA 3SG.MASC buy
'As for the cake, he bought it.'

Là doesn't always alternate with *thì*.

(21)

a. Anh ấy thì mua cái bánh đó.
3SG.MASC TM buy CL-cake-DEM
'As for him, he bought that cake.'
(as opposed to someone else who bought a different cake)

b. *Anh ấy là mua cái bánh đó.
3SG.MASC LA buy CL-cake-DEM

(22)

a. Bánh thì anh ấy mua rồi.
cake TM 3SG.MASC buy PST
'A cake, he already bought one.'

b. *Bánh là anh ấy mua rồi.
cake TM 3SG.MASC buy PST

(23)

a. Cái bánh đó thì chắc chắn anh ấy phải mua.
CL-cake-DEM TM certainly 3SG.MASC MOD buy
'That cake, he certainly has to buy it.'

b. *Cái bánh đó là chắc chắn anh ấy phải mua.
CL-cake-DEM TM certainly 3SG.MASC MOD buy

c. Cái bánh đó (thì) chắc chắn là anh ấy phải mua.
CL-cake-DEM TM certainly LA 3SG.MASC MOD buy
'That cake, it is certain that he has to buy it.'

(24)

a. Trời sáng là anh ấy đi.
sky light LA 3SG.MASC leave
'In the morning, he will leave.' (lit. 'When the sky is light is when he leaves.')

b. Trời sáng thì anh ấy đi.
sky light TM 3SG.MASC leave
'Once the morning comes, he'll leave.' (?) → more conditioned

3 Some remaining issues

Vietnamese allow multiple-topic constructions. Michaud and Brunelle (2016) treats *là* as an equative/identificational in such that case.

(25) Ở Tokyo thì máy này mỗi cái là năm ngàn.
LOC-Tokyo TM machine-DEM each-CL LA five thousand
'In Tokyo (as opposed to other places), these machines are five thousand (price) each.'
(modified from Cao 1992)

(26)

a. Cuốn sách đó (thì) từ nào (*là) tôi cũng biết.
CL-book-DEM TM word-WH 1SG OP know
'That book, I know (the meaning of) every word in it.'
(modified from Duffield 2025)

b. Mỗi cuốn sách đó (thì) là từ nào tôi cũng biết.
only CL-book-DEM TM LA word-WH 1SG OP know
'Only that book, I know (the meaning of) every word in it.'

(27) Cuốn sách đó (thì) từng chữ đều là tôi viết.
CL-book-DEM TM each-word op la 1SG write
'That book, I wrote every word of it.'

Does *là* in (25)-(27) have the same function or different functions? Given that *là* is a multiple category, which head in the syntactic structure does it occupy?

What could be the syntactic account for the cases where *là* can optionally co-occur with other elements (e.g., *rằng, liệu, thì*), and vice versa? What can the restrictions of *là* in some contexts tell us about?

4 References

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